



French ascendancy: Alex Lanier reaches for another winner on his way to men's singles gold in New Delhi, completing a remarkable double for French badminton. GETTY IMAGES

system working as intended. He was identified at a young age because he was simply better than the other children around him. "He's very strong. He arrived with maybe two or three years here. He is stronger than other kids of the same age. It's easy to identify this," Gombrowicz said.

But identifying talent is only the beginning.

"Afterwards, it's harder to propose a good environment, a good team around him," Gombrowicz said. Lanier's family played an important role in those early years. He then progressed through the French pathway, playing for a club in Normandy

before moving to the regional centre in Caen, where he spent two years.

Then came INSEP, the National Institute of Sport, Expertise, and Performance in Paris, where he could train with France's best players.

By the time he was 15, he had also begun working with Kestutis Navickas, the coach who has remained alongside him for almost five years.

For Navickas, the transformation has been about much more than adding another shot or improving a physical attribute. "Five years is a very long period of time. But basically we try to synchronise all the elements, technical, tactical, physical and mental," Navickas said.

The mental side, in particular, has been central to that development.

"For me as a coach, the mental part, the way you approach the training process, the way you approach the practice, the way you

approach the habits in the training, the way you polish the skills and how you implement that mentally, physically, tactically," Navickas said.

The evolution has not been linear.

"There are a lot of good days, bad days," he said. "What makes the most important is the trust and the belief in the process."

That trust was evident in the way Navickas watched Lanier's final.

He had to keep his emotions under control until the last point, even as the other French coach, Tinna Ludvigsen, was becoming increasingly animated. "I really tried to keep cool until the last point, give instructions to Alex," he said.

'Not individual but team win'

But Lanier's own reaction showed that he did not view the victory simply as the culmination of his personal development. He had already watched Gicquel and Delrue win their mixed doubles final earlier